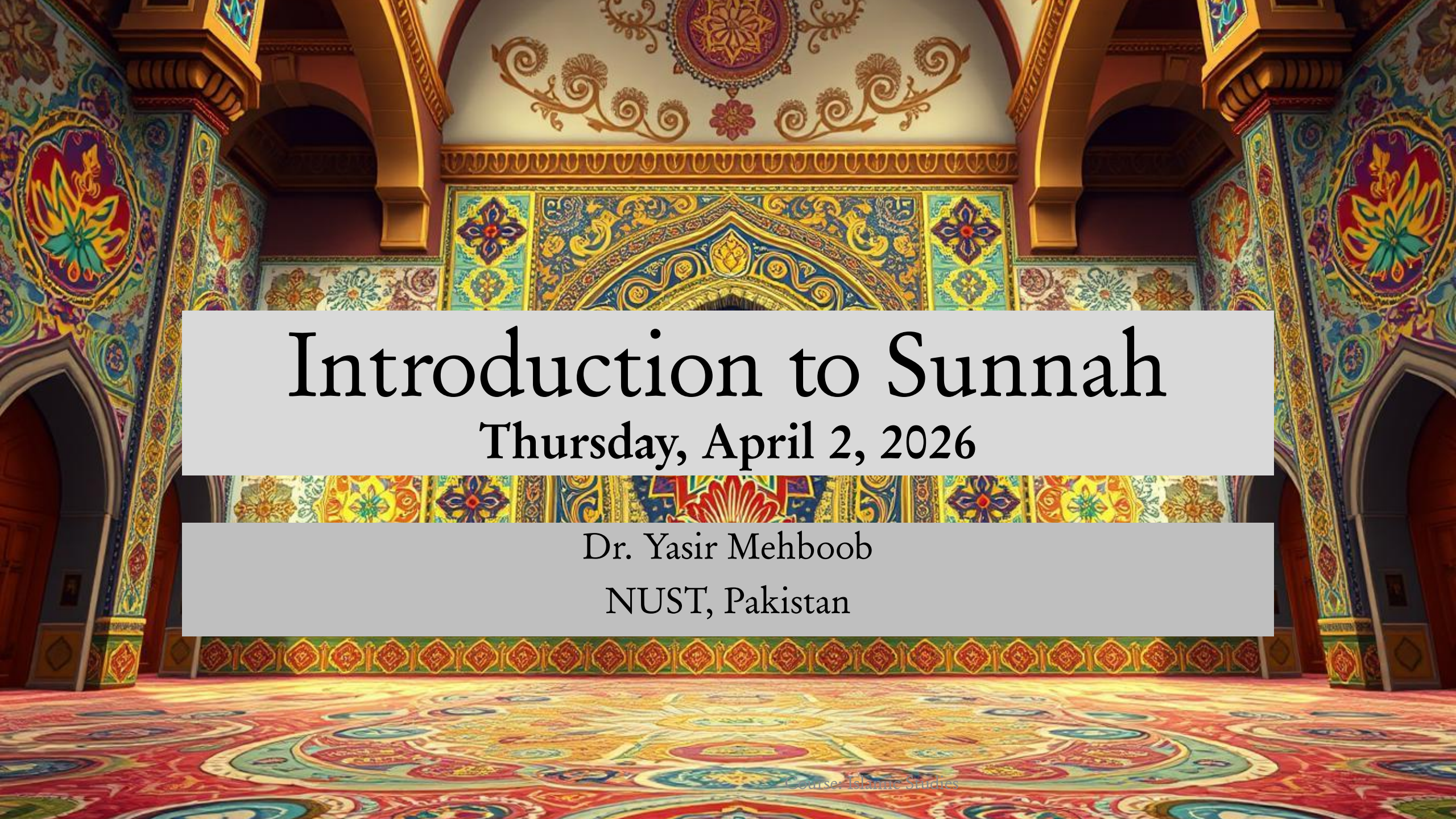


Introduction to Sunnah

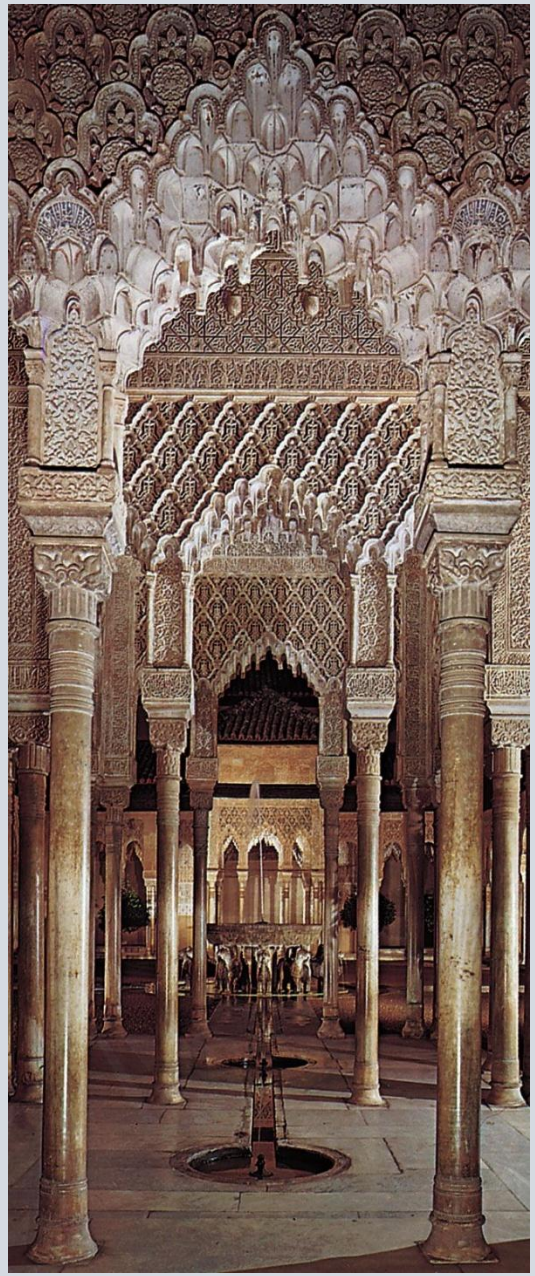
Thursday, April 2, 2026

Dr. Yasir Mehboob

NUST, Pakistan

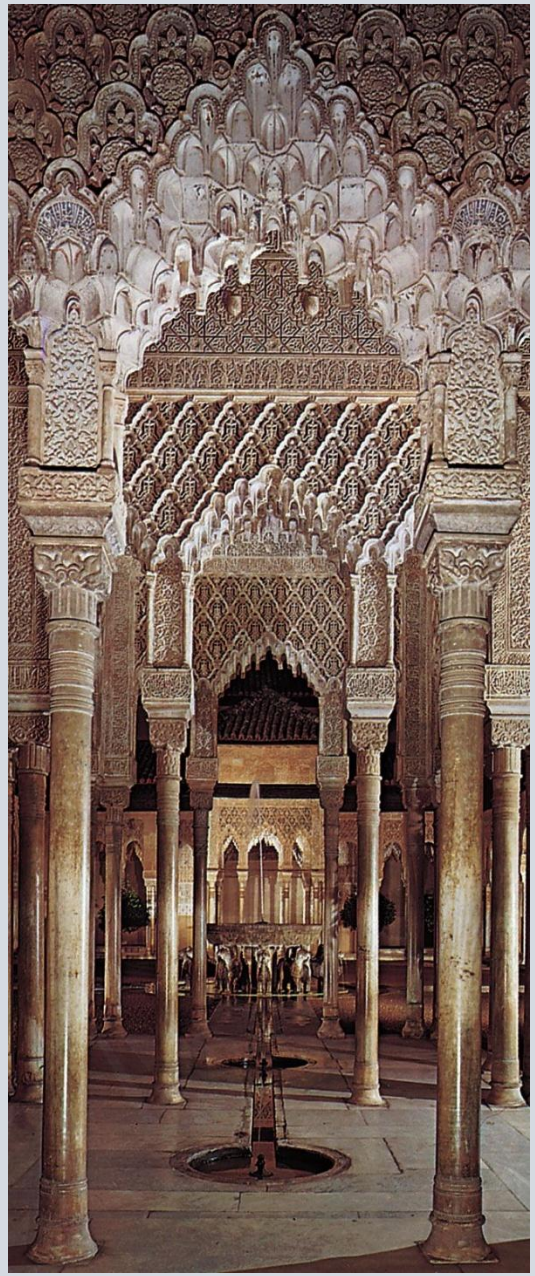
Today's Topics

- Introduction to Sunnah
- Legal Status of Sunnah (In the chapter of sources of Islamic Law)
- Sunnah, Hadith and the Difference between them
- Compilation of Hadith
- Classification of Hadith
- Authentication of Hadith



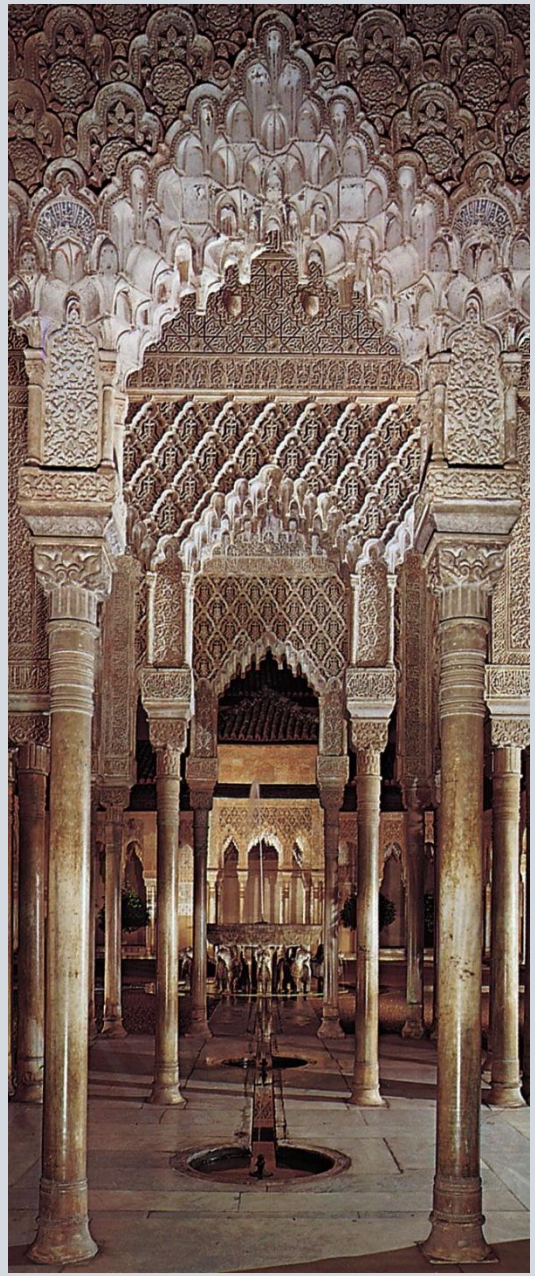
Introduction to Sunnah

- Sunnah is actually “the way of the holy Prophet ﷺ”.
- It comprises of his blessed sayings, actions, approval, moral and personal characteristics, whether before or after the prophethood.
  - When used in the context of Al-Hukm Al-Sharaie (Wajib, Mustahab, Mubah, Makrooh and Haram), it means the deeds which the holy prophet, peace and blessings upon him, performed without being obligatory
  - When used in the context of Aqeeda, it means the belief which is according to the way of the holy Prophet ﷺ. Its opposite is Bid’ah.



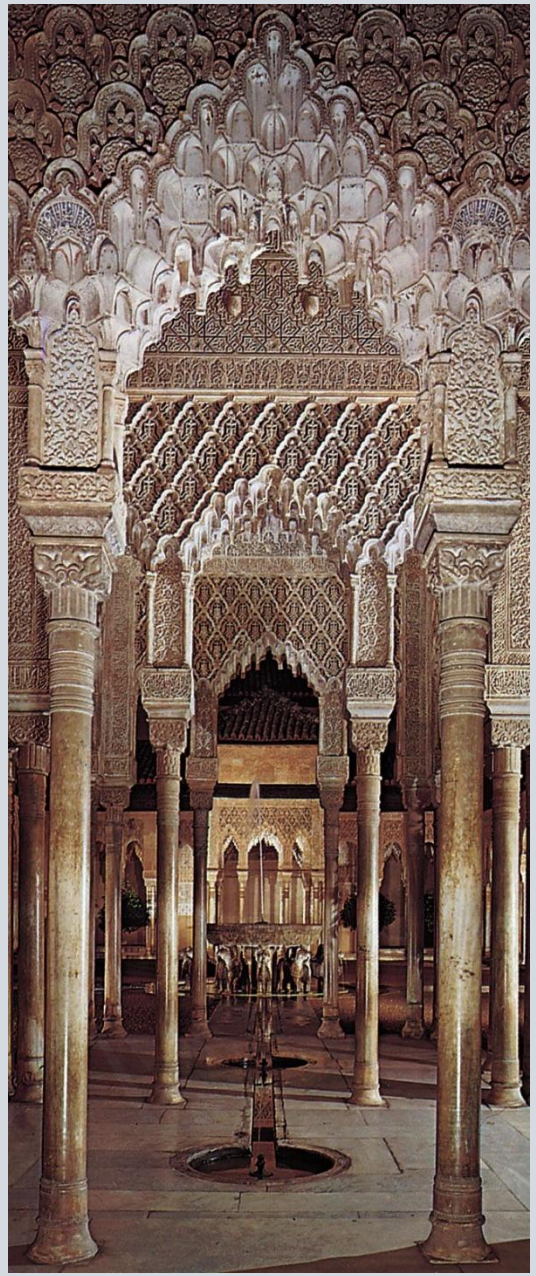
Difference between Sunnah and Hadith

The scholars use the word “Sunnah” to describe adhering to Islam in the manner prescribed, without adding to it or introducing innovations into the religion; they do not call that “Hadith.” For example, Abd Ar-Rahman ibn Mahdi said: Sufyan Al-Thawri is an imam (leading scholar) in Hadith, but he is not an imam in Sunnah; Al-Awzaai is an imam in Sunnah but he is not an imam in Hadith. Maik ibn Anas is an imam in both. (Tarikh Dimashq by Ibn Asakir, 35/183)



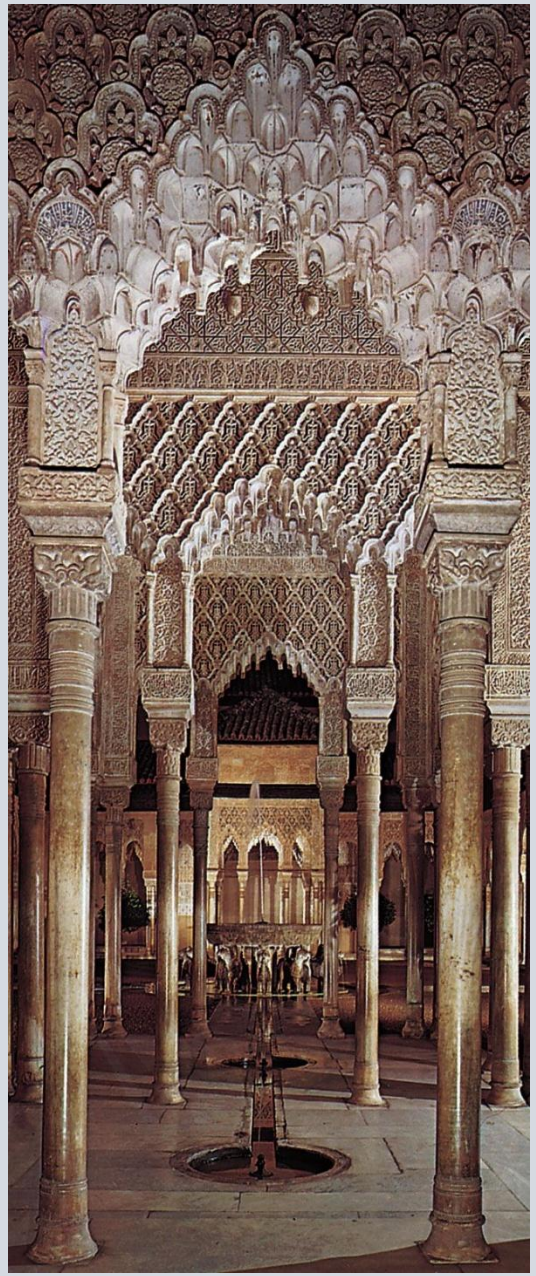
Difference between Sunnah and Hadith

- Hadith is a report about a statement, act, silent approval or an incident that is attributed to the holy Prophet ﷺ.
- We received Sunnah from generation-to-generation, while hadith has been reported, in most cases, by one individual to another. Thus the act that qualifies as sunnah is undoubtedly authentic — quite as authentic as the Quran itself — while hadith reports the Sunnah.



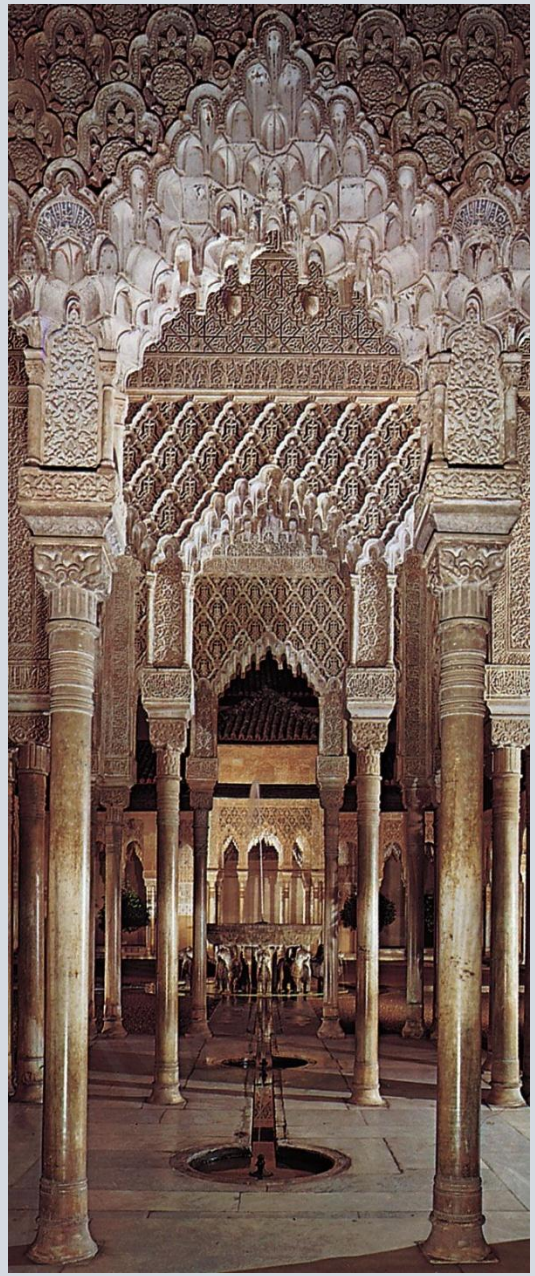
Difference between Sunnah and Hadith

- “Sunnah” is clear in what it stands for where as the context of a hadith had to be understood (and therefore interpreted) by all the narrators involved in the chain of transmission.
- “Hadith” refers to sayings and incidents that are attributed to our beloved Prophet ﷺ, even if that particular saying or incident was not verified.



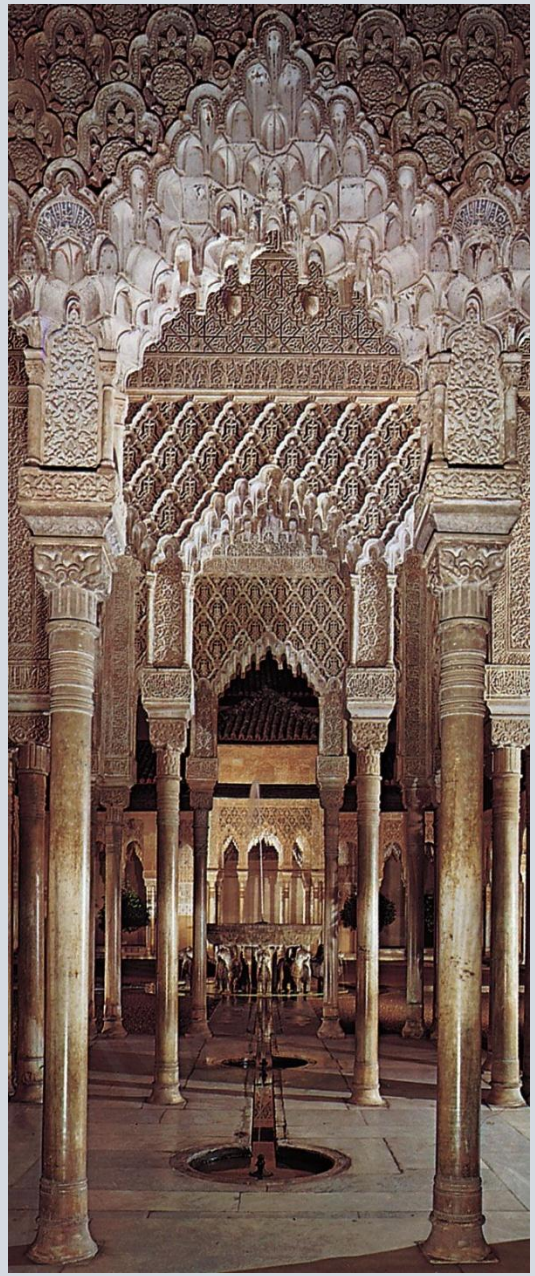
Compilation of Hadith

- During the lifetime of the holy Prophet ﷺ, there was no persistent need to write down all his blessed sayings or to record his blessed actions, because it was the time, most blessed, when he was present and could be consulted by the Ummah.
- Initially, the holy Prophet ﷺ stopped the companions from writing his blessed sayings, as Arabs were new in keeping written scripture.
- After the method of scribing the noble Quran was firmly established within the Ummah, and the Ummah became well in writing of the holy Quran, permission was then granted for the recording of the Hadith ﷺ.



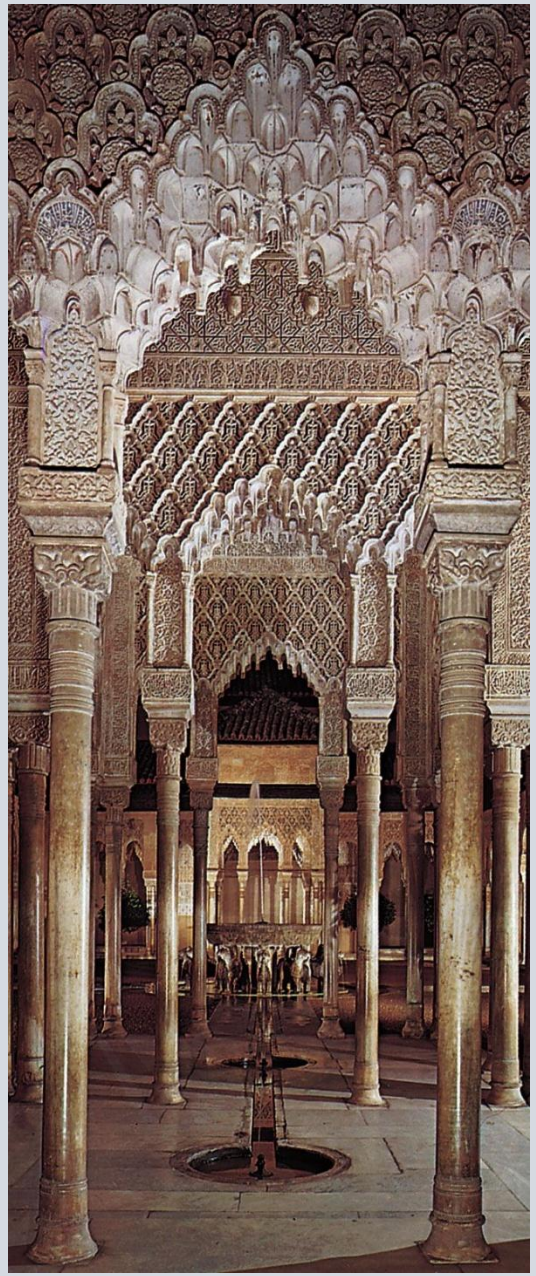
Compilation of Hadith

Some Companions wrote these in their personal collections. The Ahadith were passed down to the next generation of the Ummah known as “Tabaeen” (the followers). Several early Muslim scholars collected and recorded these into compilations which have become widespread and are the main sources of the Hadith today.



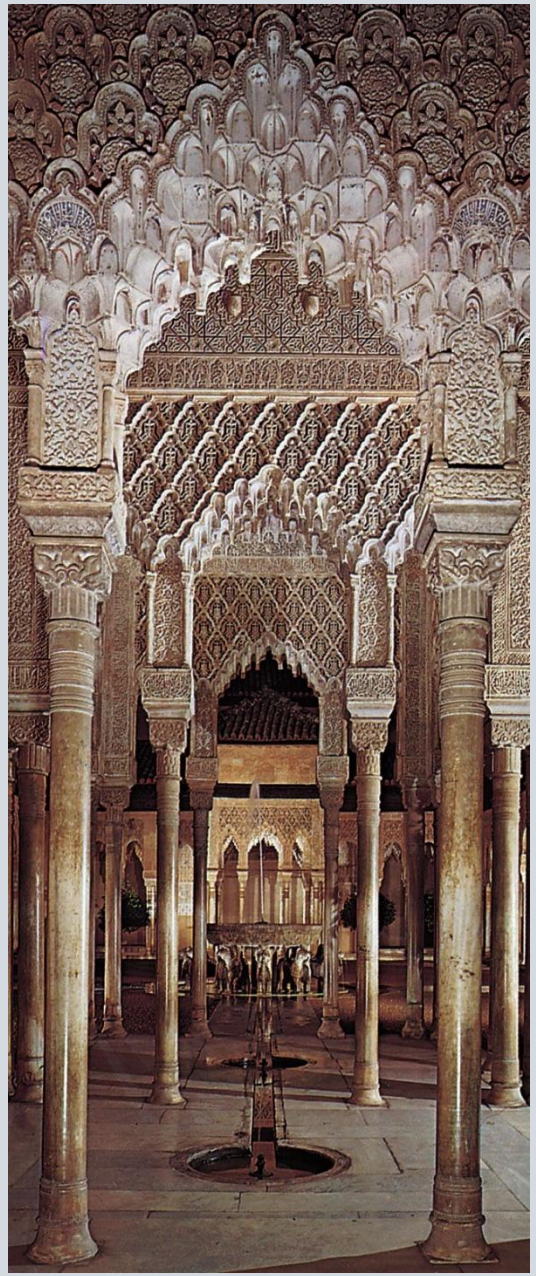
The prolific narrators among Sahaba

- **Abū Hurayrah ʿAbdur-Raḥmān ibn Ṣakhr (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhu)**
  - Passed away in 59H at the age of 78.
  - Narrated the largest number of aḥādīth: **5,374**.
  - Taught a vast circle of students, numbering around **800**.
- **ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿAbbās (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhu)**
  - The cousin of the holy Prophet ﷺ, known as *Ḥabr al-Ummah* (the scholar of the Ummah).
  - Passed away in 68H at the age of 71.
  - Narrated **2,660** aḥādīth.



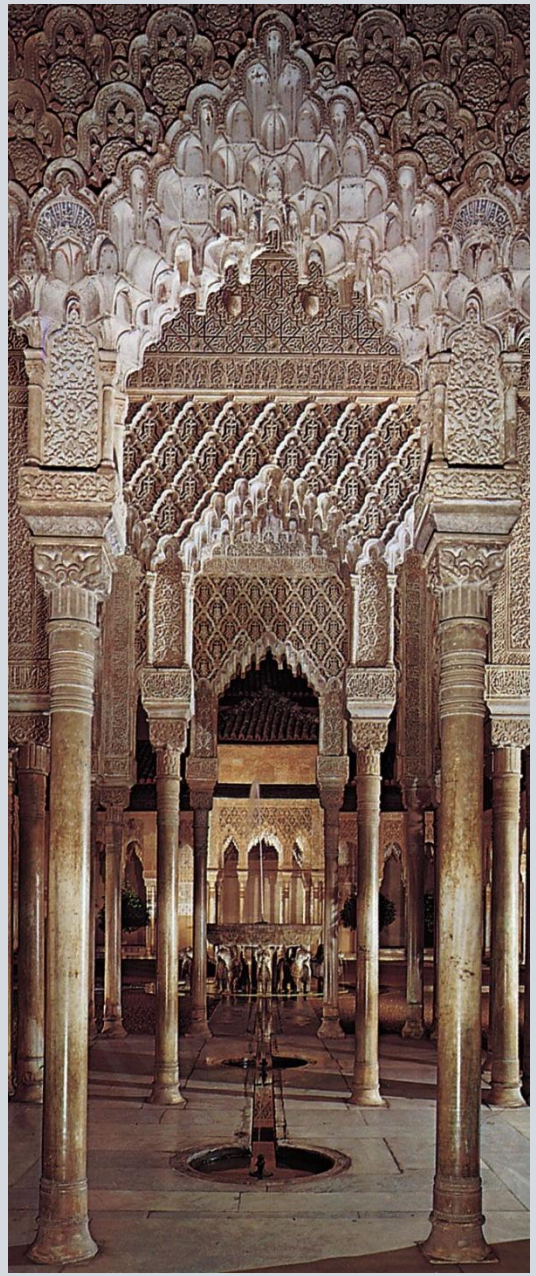
The prolific narrators among Sahaba

- **ʿĀ’ishah al-Ṣiddīqah (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhā)**
  - The beloved wife of the Prophet ﷺ and a fountain of knowledge.
  - Passed away in 58H at the age of 67.
  - Narrated **2,210** aḥādīth, especially concerning family life, worship, and the Prophet’s ﷺ private conduct.



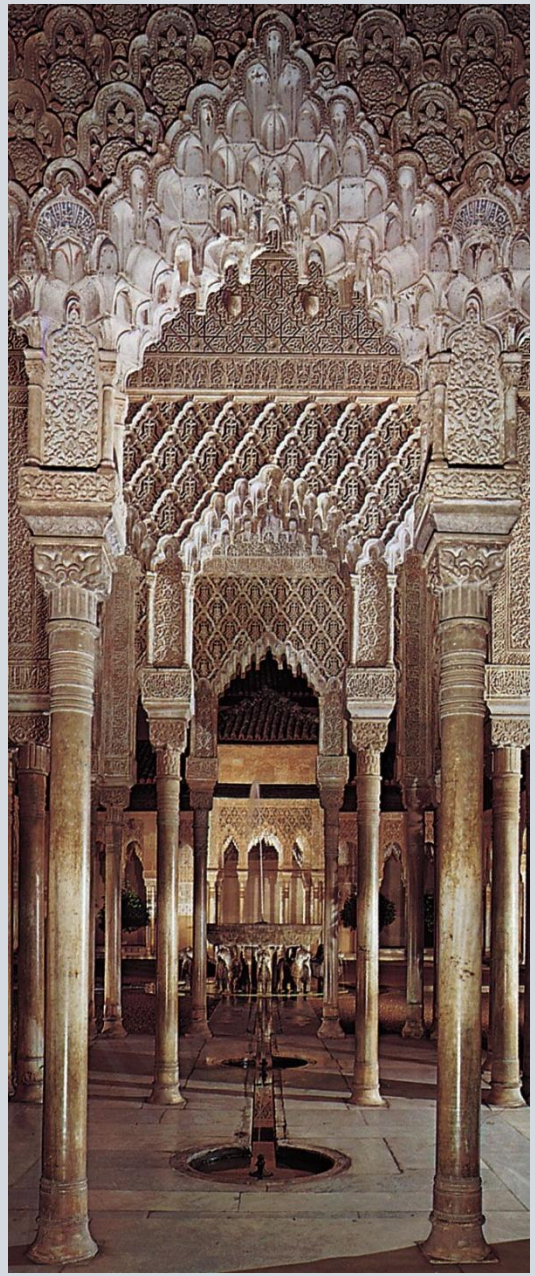
The prolific narrators among Sahaba

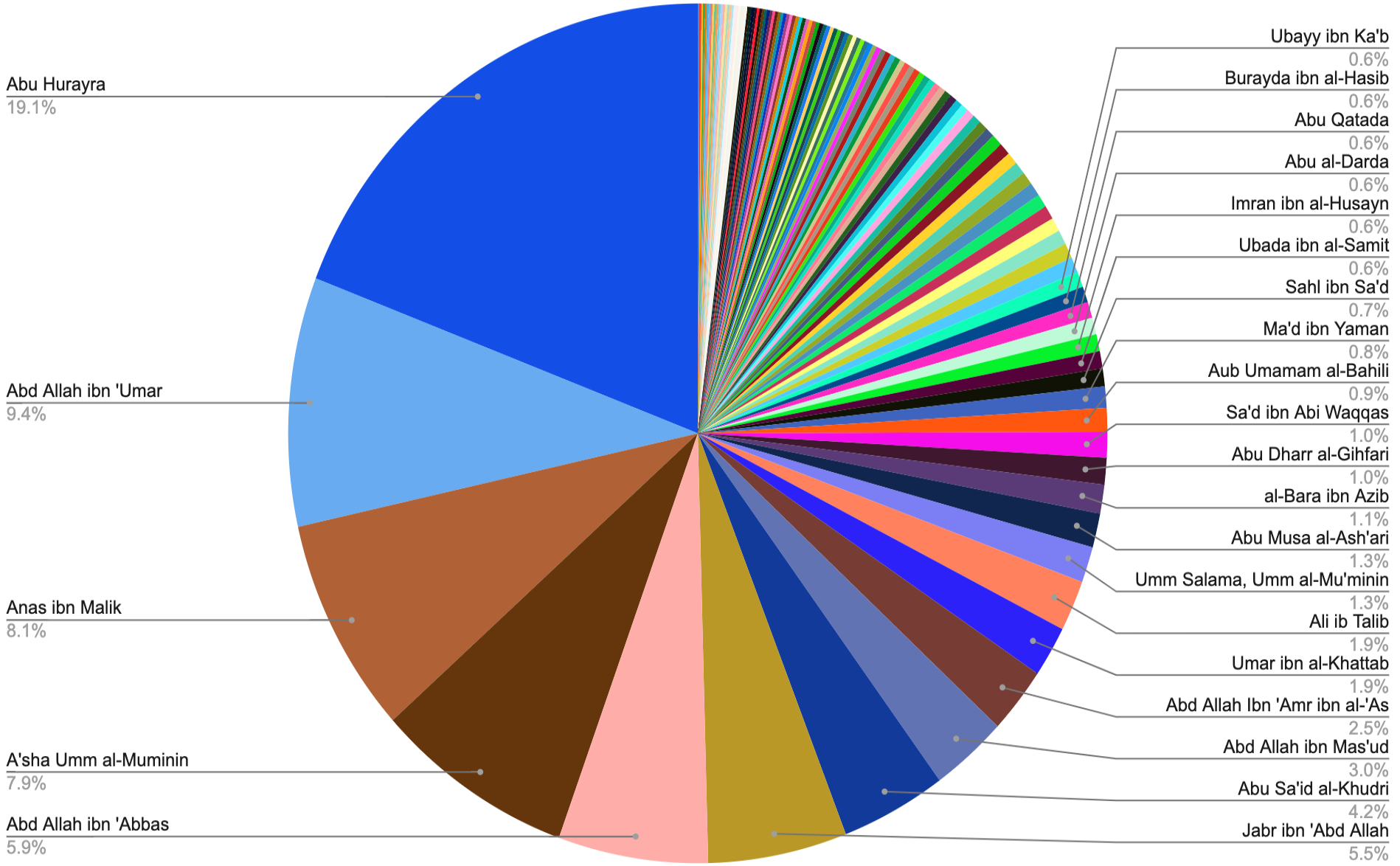
- **ʿAbdullāh ibn ʿUmar (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhu)**
  - A devoted follower of the Sunnah, known for his precision in narrating.
  - Passed away in 73H at the age of 84.
  - Narrated **1,630** aḥādīth.
- **Jābir ibn ʿAbdullāh (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhu)**
  - Passed away in 78H at the age of 94.
  - Narrated **1,560** aḥādīth.

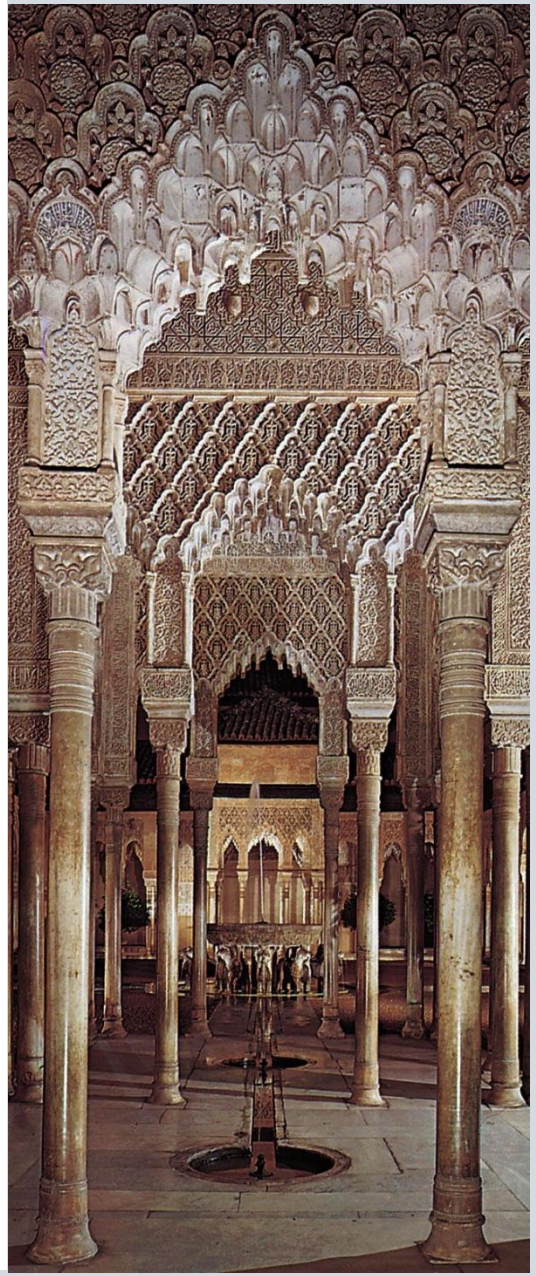


The prolific narrators among Sahaba

- **Anas ibn Mālik (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhu)**
  - Served the Prophet ﷺ for ten years in Madīnah.
  - Passed away in 93H at the remarkable age of 103.
  - Narrated **1,286** aḥādīth.
- **Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī (raḍiya Allāhu ʿanhu)**
  - Passed away in 74H at the age of 84.
  - Narrated **1,170** aḥādīth.

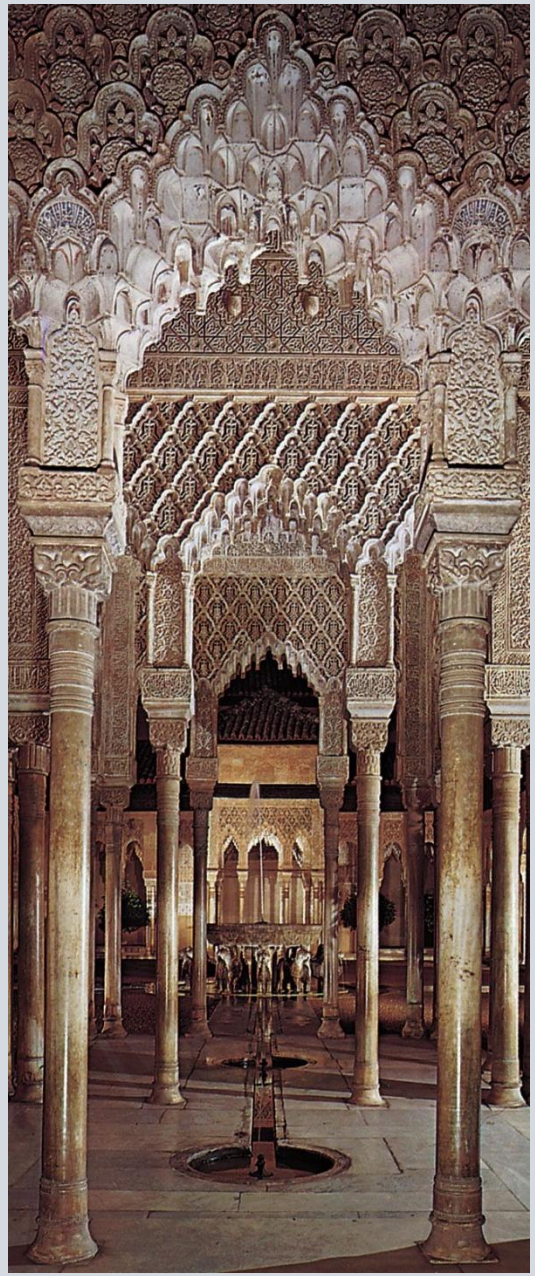



Abu Hurayra
19.1%
Abd Allah ibn 'Umar
9.4%
Anas ibn Malik
8.1%
A'sha Umm al-Muminin
7.9%
Abd Allah ibn 'Abbas
5.9%
Ubayy ibn Ka'b
0.6%
Burayda ibn al-Hasib
0.6%
Abu Qatada
0.6%
Abu al-Darda
0.6%
Imran ibn al-Husayn
0.6%
Ubada ibn al-Samit
0.6%
Sahl ibn Sa'd
0.7%
Ma'd ibn Yaman
0.8%
Aub Umamam al-Bahili
0.9%
Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas
1.0%
Abu Dharr al-Gihfari
1.0%
al-Bara ibn Azib
1.1%
Abu Musa al-Ash'ari
1.3%
Umm Salama, Umm al-Mu'minin
1.3%
Ali ib Talib
1.9%
Umar ibn al-Khattab
1.9%
Abd Allah Ibn 'Amr ibn al-'As
2.5%
Abd Allah ibn Mas'ud
3.0%
Abu Sa'id al-Khudri
4.2%
Jabr ibn 'Abd Allah
5.5%



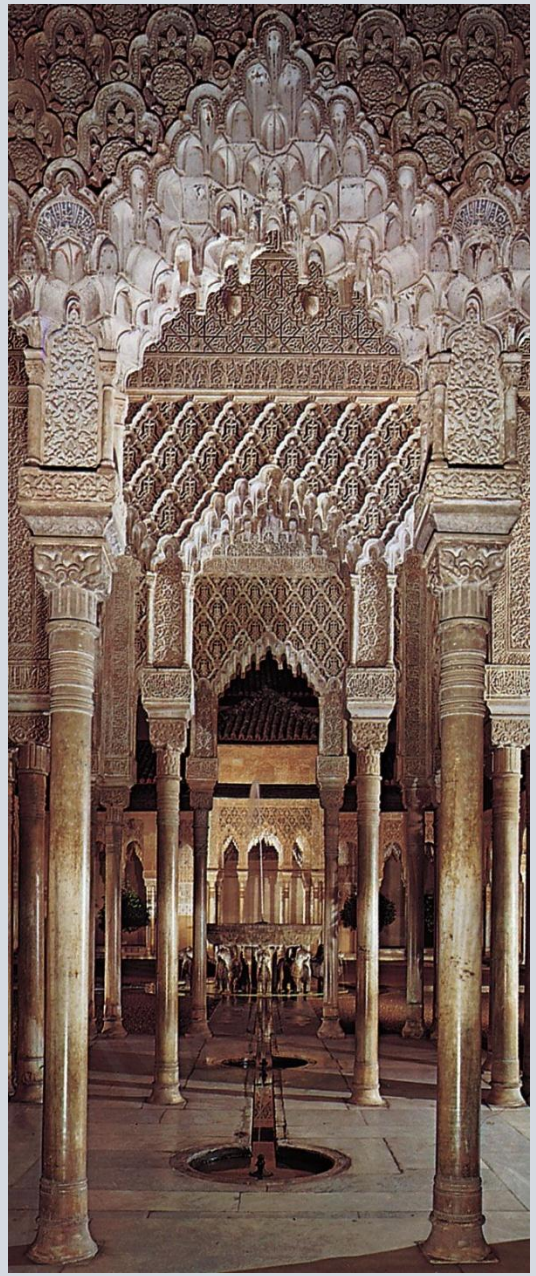
Classification of Hadith

- Hadith is classified to many categories according to different aspect;
  - The number of chains
  - The status of authenticity
  - Nature of chain regarding continuity



Classification by Number of Chains (Turuq al-Riwāyah)

- **Mutawātir**: Narrated by such a large number of trustworthy narrators in every generation that it is impossible they could have agreed upon a lie. Considered absolutely authentic.
- **Āḥād**: Narrated by fewer narrators. This is further divided into:
  - **Mashhūr**: Reported by three or more narrators in each generation, but not reaching mutawātir.
  - **ʿAzīz**: Reported by at least two narrators in every generation.
  - **Gharīb**: Reported by only one narrator at some stage of the chain.



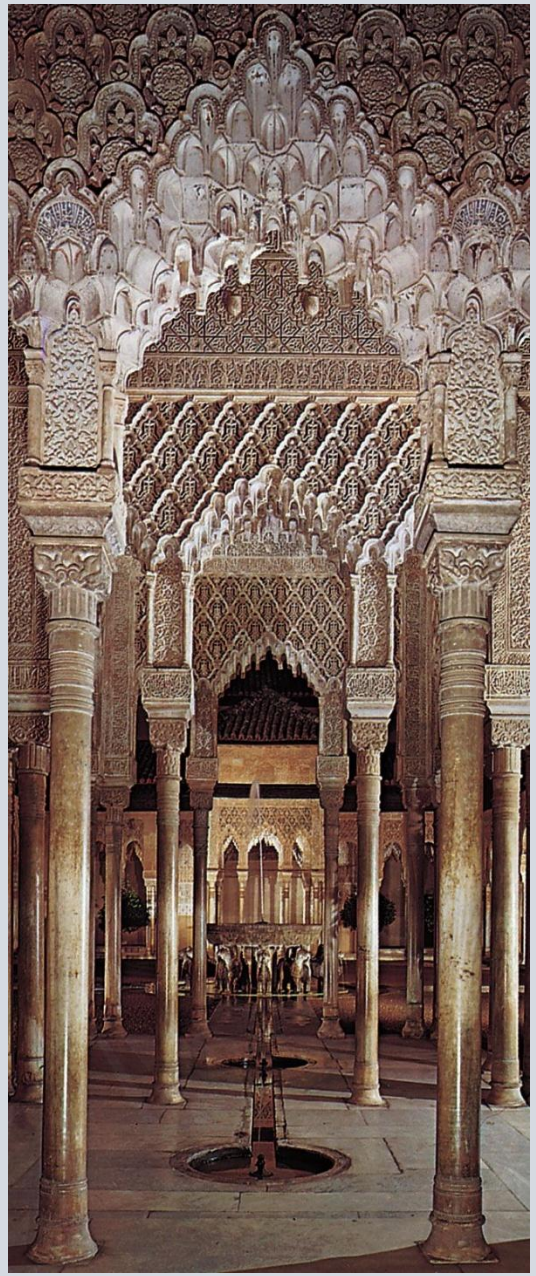
Classification by Status of Authenticity (Ṣiḥḥah wa Ḍaʿf)

Ṣaḥīḥ (Sound): Chain is continuous, narrators are trustworthy and precise, and both the text and the chain are free from contradictions and hidden defects.

Ḥasan (Good): Similar to ṣaḥīḥ, but with slightly lesser precision in some narrators. Still acceptable as evidence.

Ḍaʿīf (Weak): Chain is broken, or narrators are unreliable or unverifiable, or there are defects in the text. Usually not narrated and mentioned as evidence in legal rulings. Could be narrated in Fazail with caution.

Mawḍūʿ (Fabricated): Falsely attributed to the beloved Prophet ﷺ, often with clear signs of forgery. It is only narrated to tell that it is fabricated.



Classification by Continuity of the Chain (Ittiṣāl al-Isnād)

Musnad: A ḥadīth with a continuous chain back to the Prophet ﷺ.

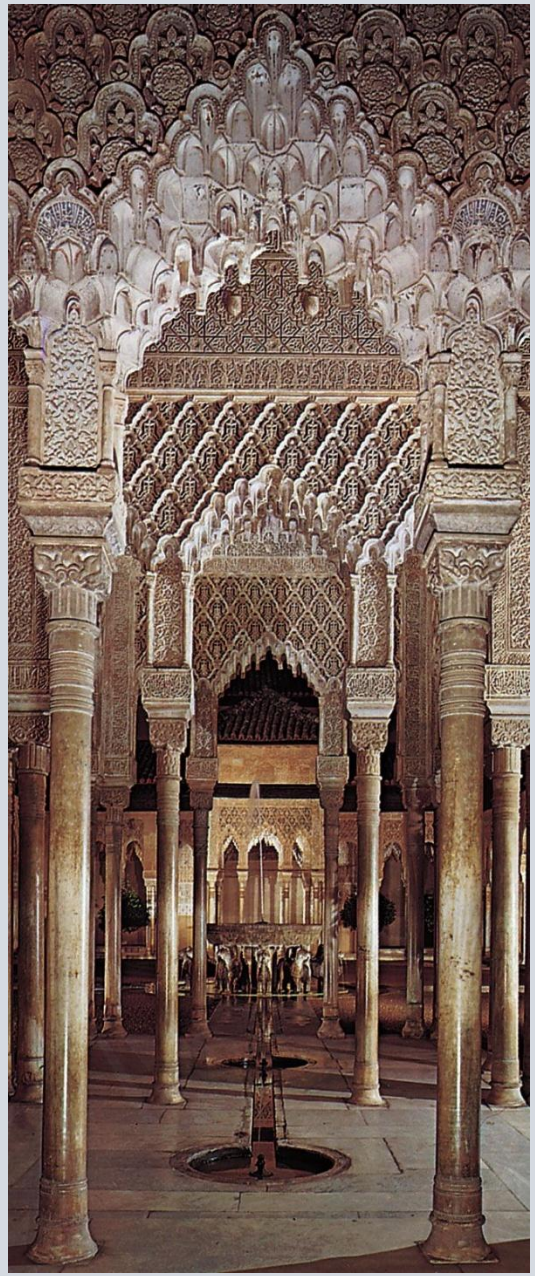
Muttasil: A connected chain, but not necessarily reaching the Prophet ﷺ (may stop at a companion).

Mursal: A tābiʿī (successor) narrates directly from the Prophet ﷺ, skipping the companion.

Munqaṭiʿ: A break in the chain at any point.

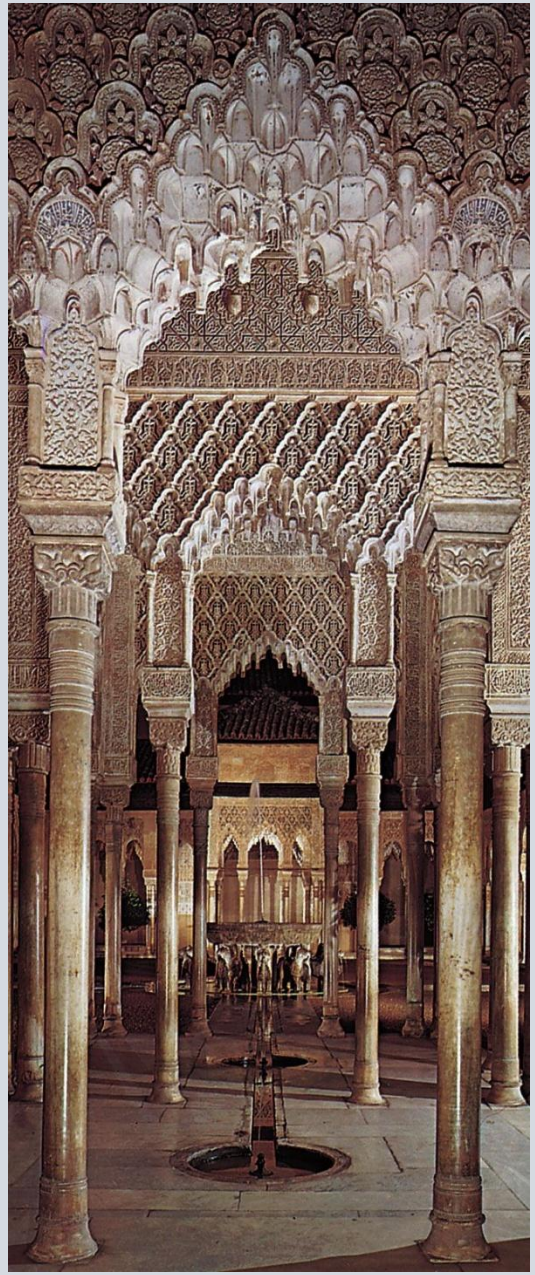
Muʿḍal: Two or more consecutive narrators missing in the chain.

Muʿallaq: The beginning of the chain is omitted, often cited directly by an author without isnād.



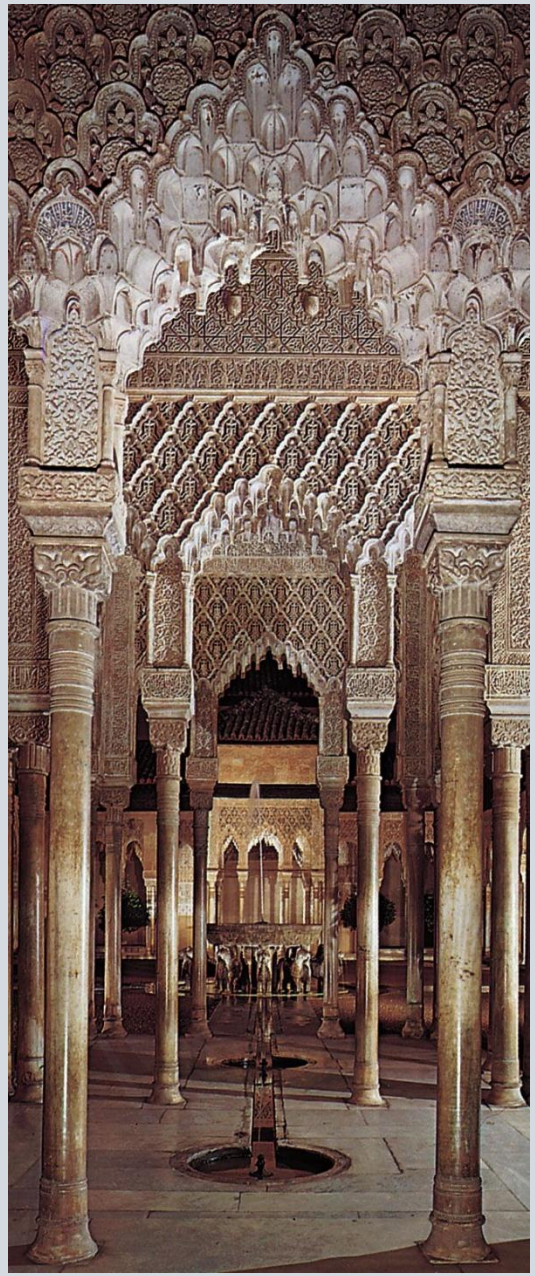
Authentication of Hadith

- An authentic (ṣaḥīḥ) ḥadīth must meet five essential conditions. These conditions have been established by the scholars of ḥadīth.
  - Ittiṣāl al-Isnād (**Continuous Chain**)
  - ʿAdālah al-Ruwāt (**Integrity of Narrators**)
  - Ḍabṭ (**Precision and Accuracy in the record keeping of the narrators**)
    - Written
    - Memorization
  - ʿAdam al-Shudhūdh (**Absence of Contradiction**)
  - ʿAdam al-ʿIllah (**Absence of Hidden Defects**)



Conditions of Sahih Hadith

- **Ittiṣāl al-Isnād (Continuous Chain)**
  - The chain of narrators must be unbroken, with each narrator having directly received the report from the one before him.
  - No missing links, gaps, or unknown transmitters are allowed.
- **ʿAdālah al-Ruwāt (Integrity of Narrators)**
  - Every narrator in the chain must be upright, trustworthy, and known for piety.
  - They must be free from major sins and not known for dishonesty or innovation.



Traits of ʿAdālah (Integrity/Uprightness)

A narrator is considered to have *ʿadālah* if he possesses the following qualities:

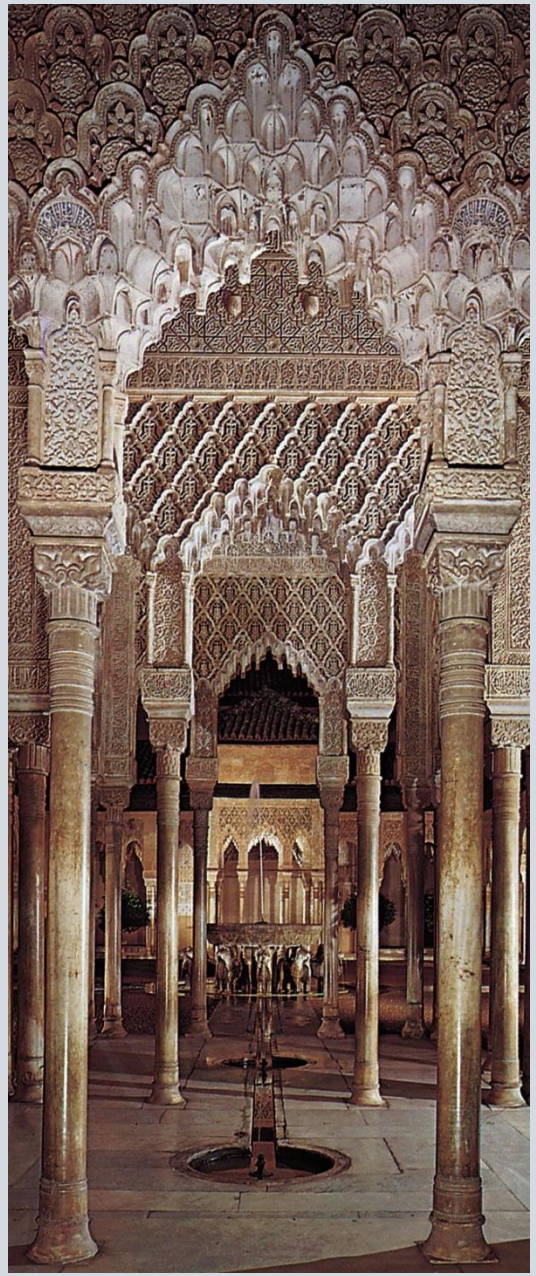
1. **Islām** – The narrator must be a Muslim, as non-Muslims are not accepted in transmitting the Sunnah.

2. **Bulūgh (Maturity)** – The narrator must have reached the age of responsibility (puberty) when he or she narrates.

3. **ʿAql (Sound Mind)** – The narrator must be sane and capable of understanding what he transmits.

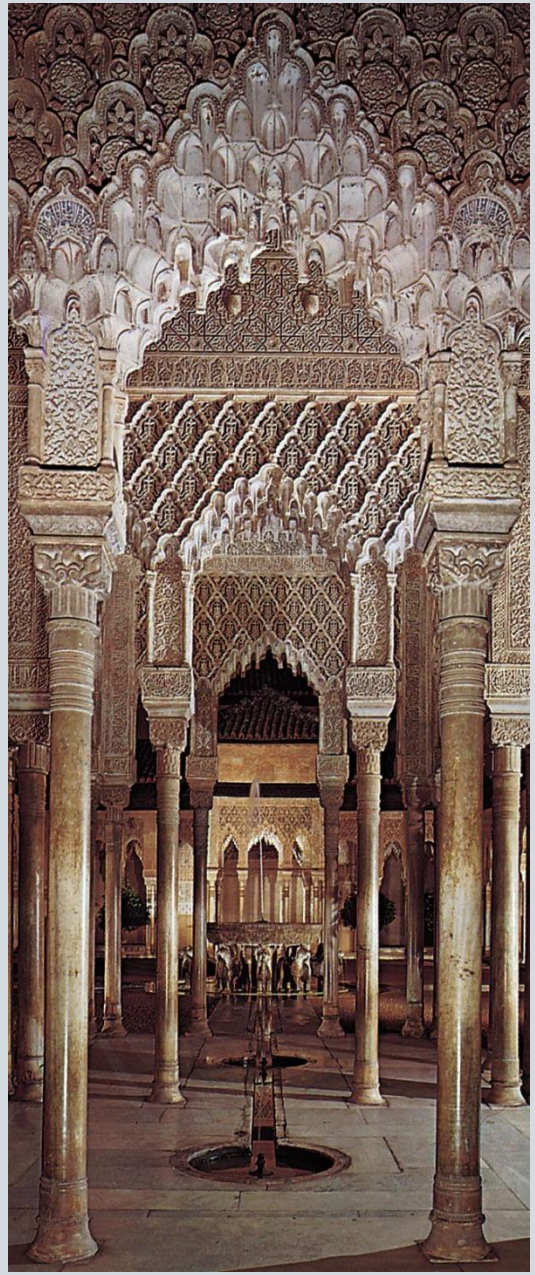
4. **Salāmah min al-Fisq (Free from Major Sin and not be Persistent in Minor Sins)** – The narrator should not be known for committing major sins or persisting in minor sins.

5. **Murū'ah (Upright Character and Dignity)** – The narrator must uphold good manners, social dignity, and avoid actions that diminish credibility (e.g., lying in worldly matters, indecency, or dishonorable behavior). In case of lying, the one who has been caught to tell lie even once loses credibility for the rest of their lives.



Conditions of Sahih Hadith

- **Ḍabṭ (Precision and Accuracy)**
  - Narrators must have strong memory and retention, or if narrating from written notes, their records must be reliable and preserved.
  - This ensures the wording and meaning are transmitted exactly as received.
- **ʿAdam al-Shudhūdh (Absence of Contradiction)**
  - The narration must not contradict stronger, more reliable reports.
  - If a narrator reports something that opposes what more trustworthy narrators have transmitted, it is considered *shādh* (irregular) and not ṣaḥīḥ.



Traits of Ḍabṭ (Precision/Accuracy)

A narrator must also demonstrate *ḍabṭ*, which relates to accuracy in preserving and transmitting what was heard:

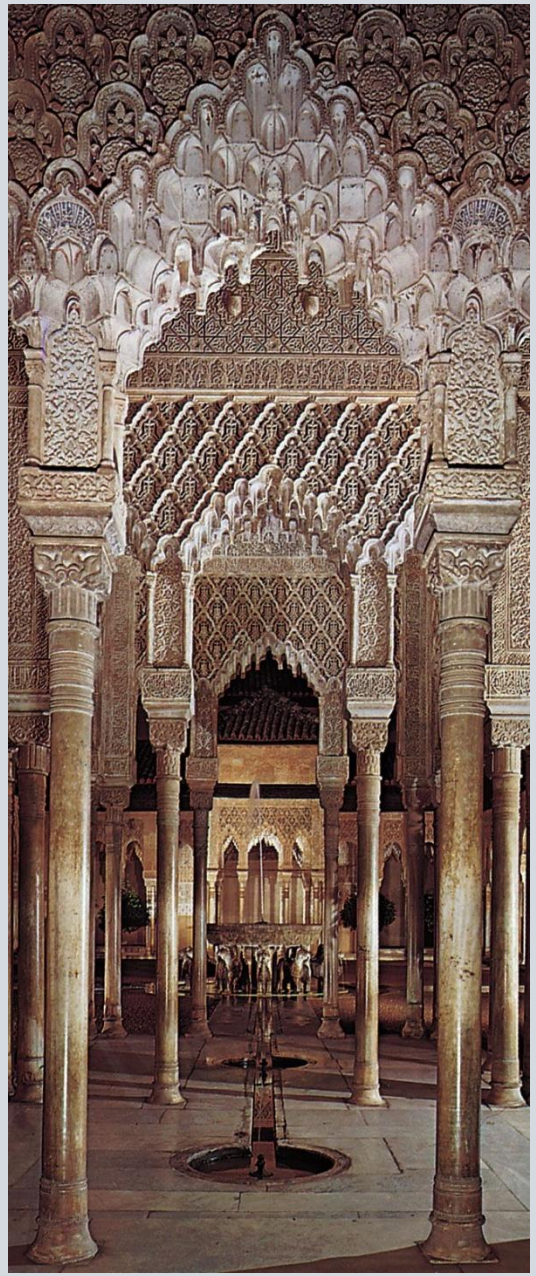
1. **Strong Memory (Ḍabṭ al-Ṣadr)** – The ability to retain narrations accurately and recall them when needed.

2. **Reliable Written Records (Ḍabṭ al-Kitāb)** – If narrating from notes, the records must be carefully preserved, must be free from tampering, and must have used consistently.

3. **Consistency** – The narrator's reports should not fluctuate or contradict themselves when compared over time.

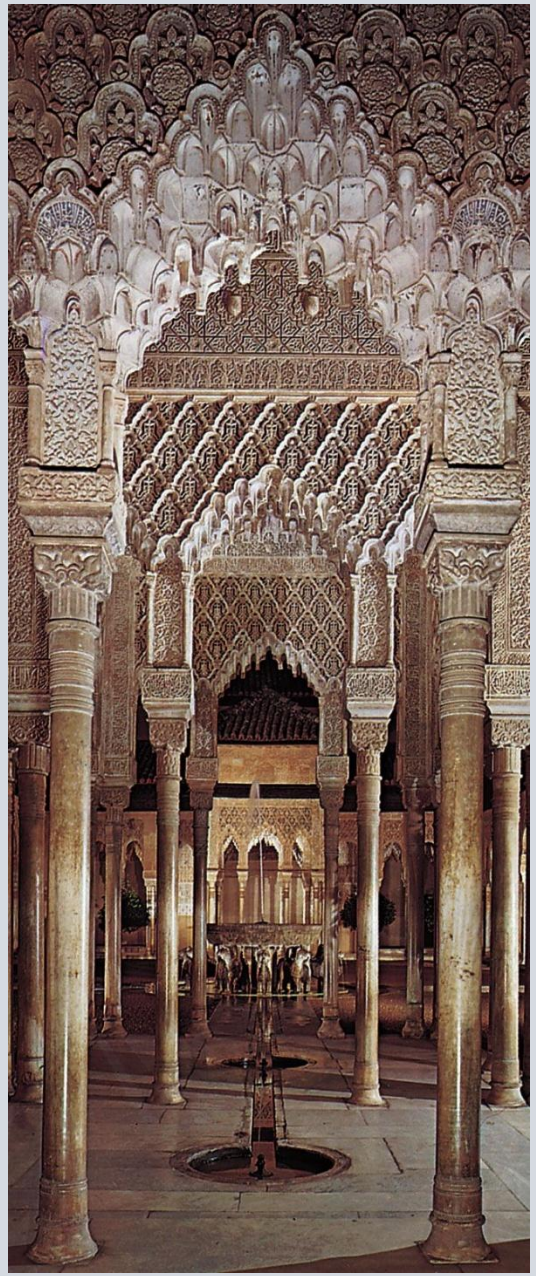
4. **Agreement with Other Trustworthy Narrators** – His narrations should align with those of other reliable transmitters, showing accuracy.

5. **Carefulness in Transmission** – The narrator must be cautious in wording, not paraphrasing carelessly, and must transmit exactly the same meaning as received. The words may differ.



Conditions of Sahih Hadith

- **ʿAdam al-ʿIllah (Absence of Hidden Defects)**
  - The narration must be free from subtle flaws (*ʿilal*) that may not be obvious at first glance.
  - These defects could include hidden breaks in the chain, errors in attribution, or unnoticed weaknesses in a narrator. Or even a subtle inaccuracy in certain narrations of the narrator, or in certain location of narrators



Conditions of Sahih Hadith

- A ṣaḥīḥ ḥadīth is one that has:
  - A continuous chain,
  - Trustworthy narrators,
  - Accurate transmission,
  - No contradiction with stronger reports, and
  - No hidden defects.

